

PASSWITHPURPOSE

UPDATED
2027
SYLLABUS

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

The Complete *Exam Guide*

Paper 1 Reading and Paper 2 Directed Writing & Composition — every question, what it tests, and exactly how to answer it.

- ◆ All 4 Paper 1 questions
- ◆ Step-by-step answer frameworks
- ◆ Timing plans for both papers
- ◆ Command words decoded
- ◆ Both Paper 2 sections
- ◆ Worked examples & model lines
- ◆ Top 10 mark-losing mistakes
- ◆ Exam-week revision checklist

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For exams in 2027, 2028 and 2029. Independent study guide; not
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How to use this guide

This guide is built for students sitting Cambridge IGCSE First Language English (0500) from June 2027 onwards. The exam was restructured for 2027, so older revision guides and many past papers no longer match the questions you will actually face.

Work through it in three passes. First, read the **Exam at a Glance** so you know the shape of both papers. Second, study one question at a time: read the framework, then try it on a past or specimen paper. Third, in exam week, use the **timing plans**, the **mistakes list** and the **checklist** to sharpen technique.

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CHECK YOUR ROUTE

Every candidate takes Paper 1. Most then take Paper 2; some schools enter students for the Coursework Portfolio (Component 3) instead. Ask your teacher which you are taking. This guide covers Papers 1 and 2.

The exam at a glance

Two written papers, each **2 hours**, each **80 marks**, each worth **50%** of your grade (A*–G). No dictionaries. Texts are printed in a separate insert.

Paper 1 – Reading

Three texts (A, B, C), about 1,400 words in total. Four compulsory questions, 20 marks each. Spend about 15 minutes reading first.

Question	Text	What you do	Marks
Q1 Comprehension	A	Short answers on explicit and implicit meaning	20
Q2(a) Summary	B	Selective summary in your own words, max 120 words	15 (10R + 5W)
Q2(b)	B	Short answer on attitudes and opinions	5
Q3 Short answers	C	Sub-questions, including word meanings in your own words	10
Q3 Language task	C	Writer's effects, about 200–250 words	10
Q4 Extended response	C	Letter, report, journal, speech, interview or article, 250–300 words	20 (10R + 10W)

Paper 2 – Directed Writing and Composition

Answer one question from each section.

Question	Text	What you do	Marks
1(a)	1–2 texts 550–650 words	Structured question: analyse and evaluate the text(s), including how the writer influences readers	5
1(b) Directed writing	Same	Discursive / argumentative / persuasive speech, letter, article or report, 250–350 words	35 (10R + 25W)
Section B Composition	None	One of four titles (2 descriptive, 2 narrative), 350–450 words	40

WHAT CHANGED FOR 2027

- Paper 1 now has **four questions of 20 marks each**. Question 1 tests all five reading skills.
- The summary question gained a **new 5-mark part, 2(b)**, on attitudes and opinions.
- Word-meaning questions in Q3 are now worth **2 marks**, and key words appear in **bold** (no longer underlined).
- Shorter writing targets: language task 200–250 words; Q4 250–300 words.
- Paper 2's reading texts are shorter, and directed writing is split into **1(a)** and **1(b)**. For the first time, Paper 2 tests how writers influence readers.

Question 1 – Comprehension

A series of short sub-questions on Text A. Some ask what the text *says* (explicit); others ask what it *suggests* (implicit). The marks in brackets tell you how many separate points to make.

The framework: Find → Prove → Phrase

- 1 **Find.** Underline the key word in the question, then locate the exact lines. Questions usually follow the order of the text.
- 2 **Prove.** For "explain" or "suggest" questions, go one step beyond the words on the page: what does this detail tell us about the person, place or situation?
- 3 **Phrase.** Answer in your own words unless the question says "give a word or phrase" or "quote". One clear point per mark.

EXPLICIT (SAYS)

"Give two reasons why...", "Identify...", "What does the writer tell us about..."

The answer is stated. Be precise; do not add commentary.

IMPLICIT (SUGGESTS)

"What does this suggest about...", "Explain how the writer feels..."

The answer is implied. State the inference, then anchor it to a detail.

Worked example

EXTRACT

Ravi arrived forty minutes early, pressed his tie flat for the third time, and read the company's mission statement on the wall until the words stopped meaning anything.

Question: What does this sentence suggest about how Ravi feels before his interview? [2]

WEAK ANSWER • 0–1

He arrived forty minutes early and pressed his tie flat.

Copies the text and never says how he feels.

STRONG ANSWER • 2

He is very nervous (1) and anxious to make a good impression (1), shown by his repeated, restless checking of his appearance.

EXAMINER-STYLE TIP

Count the marks and give exactly that many distinct points. A 3-mark question answered with one long idea still scores 1.